

Prepositions

PREPOSITIONS CONNECT NOUNS AND PRONOUNS TO OTHER WORDS IN A SENTENCE.

Prepositions never appear alone. They are short words that convey the relationship of a noun or pronoun to another part of a sentence—often the physical position of one thing in relation to another.

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Simple prepositions

Prepositions are common in written and spoken English. They usually appear as part of a prepositional phrase, and include words like *for*, *about*, *with*, *of*, and *on*. A prepositional phrase is made up of a preposition followed by its object, which is a noun, pronoun, or noun phrase.



• In **formal writing**, sentences should **not end** with **prepositions**, but this practice is common in spoken English. “What are you talking about?” is a good example.

• **Prepositional phrases** only ever contain the **object** of a clause. They never contain the subject. In the sentence “They sped **down a hill**,” *hill* is the object, and *they* is the subject.

Daisy went **for** a long bicycle
a hill and **through** a stream

Winston Churchill, objecting to strict rules about **prepositional word order**, famously said, “That is nonsense **up with which** I shall not put.”

Parallel prepositions

Writers can improve their sentences by using consistent language. If different prepositions are required for different nouns, they must all be included in the sentence. If one preposition is being used to introduce a series of nouns, it only needs to be used before the first noun. The same preposition can be used before each noun, but this is repetitive.

The noun objects *hill* and *stream* require different prepositions, so both must be included in the sentence.

They raced **down a hill and **through** a stream.**

This preposition applies to both nouns, so it only needs to appear before the first item in this list.

They sped **through a stream and a forest.**